

Staying up all night to cram right before the exam

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · cheatgrid.com

Staying up can feel like doing something about being behind, even once it's stopped teaching you anything. **The extra hours rarely cover you** the way you're hoping they will.

THE GOAL

You're trying to walk into the exam able to use what you already know well, not trying to cram in everything you haven't covered yet.

CHECKLIST

Sitting at your desk close to midnight, weighing one more hour of review against putting the books away and going to sleep.

- ☐ Close the book, laptop, or notes you're using, and set them somewhere **you won't reach for them again** tonight.
- ☐ If it's already so late that only a couple hours of sleep are left, take them anyway instead of staying up longer.
- ☐ If you still want to look at something, review only the point you're least sure of, not material you haven't covered yet.
- ☐ Write down the one or two things you're still shaky on, so you're not holding them in your head.
- ☐ Eat something small if you haven't, so hunger doesn't wake you up later.
- ☐ Lay out what you need tomorrow (ID, calculator, pens) so the morning isn't a scramble.
- ☐ Set your alarm to give yourself time to eat and get there without rushing.
- ☐ If you've had caffeine today, don't have any more before you try to sleep.
- ☐ Put your phone out of reach of the bed, not on the pillow beside you.
- ☐ Get into bed at the time you decided, **even if you don't feel tired yet**.
- ☐ If a worry comes back once you're lying down, add it to the same list instead of turning it over in your head.
- ☐ If you can't fall asleep after a while, get up, do something calm and boring for a few minutes, then go back to bed.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** New material learned during an all-nighter sticks worse, because you're **sleep-deprived while you're learning it**, not just tired afterward.
- 2** Staying awake weakens your recall of material you already knew before tonight.
- 3** Feeling used to little sleep isn't the same as being fine. You haven't adapted.

The sleep pattern behind your score

DON'T

Trading sleep for extra studying doesn't pay off the way it feels like it will.

Students who made that trade had **more trouble in class** and worse marks the very next day. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

How you slept last night barely predicts your exam score. How you slept for weeks before it does instead. So if you're behind on sleep tonight, the fix is next month's habits, not tonight's willpower. [Source 2](#)

What the sleep loss itself does to your brain

WATCH

You might feel alert enough to push through, but by exam time you're thinking at a level some countries call **drunk driving**. Stay awake a full 24 hours and it gets worse: the match rises to a blood alcohol level twice as high. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

New material learned during an all-nighter sticks worse, because you're **sleep-deprived while you're learning it**, not just tired afterward. If you keep going, spend the time only on material you've already learned once. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Staying awake weakens your recall of material you already knew before tonight. That hit is worse if you walk straight from the sleepless night into the exam with **no recovery sleep** first. [Source 4](#)

The trap that keeps you going

KNOW

Feeling anxious about the exam and sleeping badly before it don't take turns: **they feed each other**. So calming the anxious feeling before bed protects the sleep you're about to lose too. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

Feeling used to little sleep isn't the same as being fine. You haven't adapted. In a lab study, self-rated sleepiness seemed to level off while measured performance **kept getting worse**. [Source 6](#)

DON'T

More caffeine to push through doesn't just keep you awake now. Pooled research finds it cuts about 45 minutes off your total sleep time and leaves what sleep you get **lighter and more broken**. If you want any sleep before the exam, your last caffeine needs to come well before you lie down. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you study the right way, pulling an all-nighter doesn't cost you anything a good strategy can't make up for.

ACTUALLY

The strategy doesn't decide this. Research comparing students who stayed up all night to students who slept found that skipping sleep entirely **wasn't an effective way** to reach a better grade, whatever filled the hours awake. [Source 8](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.uclahealth.org/news/release/cramming-for-a-test-dont-do-it-say-ucla-researchers>
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6. <https://www.med.upenn.edu/uep/assets/user-content/documents/VanDongen2003CumulativeCost.pdf>
7. <https://eprints.leedsbeckett.ac.uk/id/eprint/9625/>
8. <https://aasm.org/college-students-who-pull-all-nighters-and-get-no-sleep-more-likely-to-have-a-lower-gpa/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Exams and tests at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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